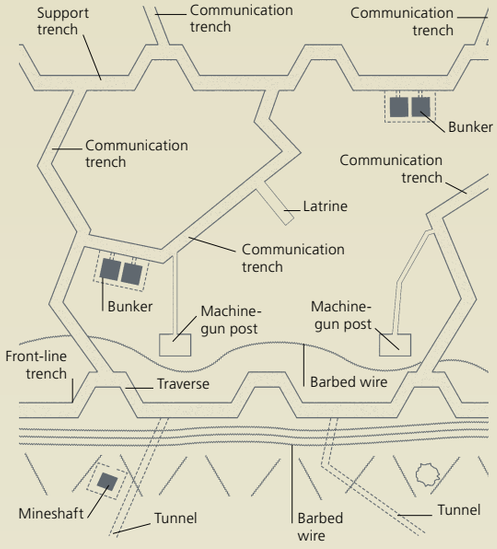
GERMAN TRENCH

Through most of World War I, a line of field fortifications stretched for more than 700km (450 miles) along the Western Front from Nieuport in Belgium to the Swiss border. The first trenches, improvised in the autumn of 1914, were intended as temporary structures, but these hastily-dug ditches gradually evolved into permanent in-depth defensive systems incorporating concrete bunkers and strongpoints, protected by dense belts of barbed wire.

The opposing lines of trenches were typically separated by a "no man's land" some 200–300m (220–330 yards) wide, although in places they could be as close as 25m (28 yards). The nature of the trenches varied depending on the terrain. In the dry, firm chalk of Artois and the Somme, soldiers could dig deep into the earth and create safe, comfortable shelters. But in the wet, soft terrain of Flanders, where the Bayernwald trench, featured here, was dug, deep structures flooded and earth walls crumbled unless shored up with timber or wicker. Life for soldiers in these shallow trenches was often a miserable struggle against mud and damp. The Germans at least had the advantage of having chosen their position to dig in at the outset, selecting the higher ground that was drier and less exposed to enemy fire.

At minimum, a trench needed a wall facing the enemy that was taller than a man, for snipers picked off anyone whose head showed over the top of the parapet. Construction and repair work had to be carried out under cover of darkness. Keeping the trenches solid and dry used up much of soldiers' energies through the war.



Simplified German trench system
After 1916 the Germans kept their front-line trenches lightly manned. They were linked by a network of communication passages to support and reserve trenches to the rear.



Pride in their work
German officers and men pose in a newly constructed trench of unusually high quality. It is far too wide to be a front-line trench.

> "ATTACKS ALTERNATE WITH COUNTERATTACKS AND SLOWLY THE DEAD PILE UP IN THE FIELD OF CRATERS BETWEEN THE TRENCHES."
>
> **ERICH MARIA REMARQUE** IN HIS NOVEL *ALL QUIET ON THE WESTERN FRONT*



Grenade launcher
The Germans were quicker than the Allies to produce specialist weapons for trench warfare such as this grenade launcher.



Winding line
Trenches were never dug in a straight line. Turnings prevented blast or shrapnel raking the whole length of the trench and also blocked the line of fire of any enemy units that broke into the trench.



Firestep
A wooden A-frame provides a firestep, enabling a soldier to step up and fire over the parapet. In drier areas firesteps would be dug out of the wall of the trench.